

Career Planning and Resilience

What is career?

Career is an occupation or job undertaken for a significant period of a person's life and with opportunity of progress. Remember that a job is a paid position or regular employment.

The First principle of career success (because it is life-long) is, love that career! This is the basis of the ease of your journey towards career resilience.

Career Planning

This is the systematic process of creating a path towards enhancing the future value of an employee.

It involves setting career goals, deciding professional education, and training that are needed and determining opportunities that may suit the individuals' interests, skills and passion. This will involve setting SMARTER goals along ones' career path in the short, medium and long term.

Why do you need career planning- normally, or during description?

- To get faster in your life goals in career- The Harvard Business School example of goal setting.
- To be able to cope better in case of unforeseen- i.e. disruption.

Tim Clark said: "The world would change many times the environment will change many times and you may end up in the same company even after several changes in the company." And against your initial plan.

- Not that you will achieve exactly what you have planned or written in your plan, but planning ahead will guide you to be prepared for any uncertainties and you will be sure of what you don't want even if you are not sure of what you want.

In the word of Tim Clark (a teacher of entrepreneurship)," the age of planning is dead, we are in the age of modelling"

What is career Modelling?

Career planning has metamorphosed into career modelling.

- Career planning helps to create the big long-term goals into small actionable goals/ steps that can be seen in the short term and that develops into the bigger goals.
- It helps to outline career goals, monitor and evaluate and reevaluate them as time passes just like the parable of the pipeline.

Models of Career Planning

➤ The 4-step model:

1. Self-assessment.
2. Career exploration.
3. Career identification.
4. Action planning.

➤ **The 6-step model for career planning.**

1. Self-exploration and assessment.
2. Career research
3. Exploration and experimentation.
4. Decision making and career selection.
5. Final planning and action.
6. Job search and acceptance.

1. Self-Exploration and Assessment (Self-discovery)

The first step in career planning is self-exploration otherwise known as self-discovery. You must know and understand yourself to be able to plan towards a reasonable goal for yourself. This involves doing a thorough SWOT analysis of yourself.

Strengths

What are the things you are good at doing? Your skills/ talents, your passion for things. They are the things you find easy to do.

Skills

Skills are the things you can do that you have acquired through training.

Talents

Talents are the skills you have that you didn't need to learn. They are God given gifts. You are highly skilled at doing them.

Passion.

Your passion is to love doing something and you enjoy doing it. There needs to be a very good clarification between your talents, strengths and your passion. Sometimes, the things you are skillful at or talented in may not be what you love. Sometimes, you may be passionate about what you are skilled at. For example, I used to have a student whom loved drawing. He was so passionate about drawing. However, he couldn't draw well, so the things he drew at that time were not nice looking. In that case you can see that the boy is passionate but not skilled.

Also, there are people that are skilled at something but are not passionate about it. I've met a woman who didn't like teaching but was very good at teaching. So, what can we do to make the best of our career in this area. When making a career plan, you need to consider the fact that you love this, however, you don't know how to do it. If you love it, there is more likely hood that the things you need to do to learn that and be very skilled in them, you would be willing to commit whatever is necessary, it is possible.

Also, if you are skilled at something, a lot of times, you may not be passionate about it, and it may be tough to develop the passion except you look inwardly for the reason why you should love doing it. So, if you are good at something and you discover that it is something that brings in a lot of joy as well as money for you, it may be easier for you to develop passion for that thing. But if you are talented in something and you don't see it bringing out joy and money for you, you may not be able to get passionate about it. Because the jobs people are very good at doing, are the jobs they

eventually make money from. So if you are not passionate, you may not be able to stay on the job till you start making money and that is why passion is important.

Passion is not everything. There is a lot of debate on passion and talent, which I would want us to explore a bit. A lot of people believe that when you're passionate, you're likely to excel on that job, you're likely to make money from it. However, other people believe that passion is not everything because sometimes, you are passionate, but you are not skilled in it.

But usually, why the proponents of passion support passion are because they believe that when you are passionate about a particular endeavor, even if it is not making you feel passionate. Particularly if you are passionate about a career for example, and that career is not bringing in money for now, you will wait till that career starts bringing in money, and when you are able to wait till it starts bringing in money, then it becomes useful for you and you grow wealth through your career.

That is why a lot of people go for passion rather than just being skilled but we must note that it is not all the time that it works for everyone like that because passion is relative. We see people saying they are passionate about this job, or you will give them some things on that same job and they will look at it as being demeaning. If you are passionate about a job, you will do anything to get that job done.

Pertaining to self-exploration and assessment, you need to know your motivation; what drives you to work. Is it money? Of course if money drives you to work, you don't want to rethink it. You need to discover what drives you besides money. What drives you more maybe could be making impact. You need to know what your values are; your core values. When you know your core values, it is going to direct the kind of career you should focus on. You also need to know what turns you off generally in life, particularly when it comes to career; know the kind of environment that excites you or demoralizes you. There are some people that can't stay in a room where drugs smell. That kind of person cannot study medicine or pharmacy. Also, there are some people who hate to see blood coming out from the body, is not likely to be able to do medicine. If it happens that the person is very passionate about practicing medicine, the person may want to go for some therapy to be able to overcome the fear of blood. A person that hates to stand in front of a crowd has the fear of crowd; may not do well as a trainer would, except the person goes for therapy and gets re-trained on it. So you need to know yourself before you can start thinking and talking about what kind of career planning you should have for yourself.

Weaknesses

Weaknesses are the things you don't find easy to do; you are weak in those areas. For example, you may be weak at managing people, yet you want to grow in your career to become a leader. You may be weak at communicating your ideas through writing and speaking, you know weaknesses are the things you can't do well. So for weaknesses, there are weaknesses that you can work on and there are some you can't work on.

For example, if you are basketballer, you can work on throwing the ball into the net, but you may not be able to do a skill in basketball; dunking, if you are a short person maybe 5 feet 9 inches, like me, you may not be able to dunk compare to those of about 6, 7 feet tall would do. It's a kind of weakness you can't change as you can't change your height, but you can work on being able to throw the ball even better than someone taller, in some aspect. So, there are some of your weaknesses that you just accept and some of those others, you work on them. It is important that you know your weaknesses, at least you know those ones that you may not be able to work on and

you know the ones you can work on, and then you move on from there. When you know the kind of weakness you have, and when you get to the next stage, you will be able to know how important it is. The next thing is your opportunities and then your threats.

Opportunities and Threats

These are usually a kind of strength you have that most people don't have; it is outside of you. Threats are also outside of you. It buys your progress as a person. For example, if you are an accountant, and you've been working in a particular unit for years. And you just discovered that there is something that has been re-occurring in every unit or company you worked in, you realized after looking back that there is one particular problem that most people have in accounting and most companies are not able to solve that problem. Each of those companies you worked in, you were the only one that has been able to solve those problems. Accountants before you and probably even after you would give you some calls to put them through on how to do that thing. You can decide to say you want to write a book on that thing, soon, or you want to consult for organizations to solve such problems, it is an opportunity for you.

You need to understand that as a career person, you have to explore yourself to be able to see the biggest impact you can make in the world. Every one of us is like a piece of a jigsaw puzzle and if the pieces of the jigsaw puzzles are missing, there will be problem, even if just few of the pieces are missing, there will be chaos in the world and can be chaos in the individuals' life but if you can find your part of the jigsaw puzzle; being able to know yourself and know that what you can't do and how you can add value to the world. It is easier for you to solve problems in the area that you choose. If you are not able to discover yourself, you will not be able to discover how you can fit in to solve the world's problem.

So, about the chaos thing, for example, a doctor just discovered that he will have been better as an astronaut, if he keeps managing being a doctor, he may keep feeling unfulfilled until the day he is able to speak up, maybe he will have to learn the skill to become an astronaut and then he starts practicing there, which will make him happy and fulfilled, then he can start solving word problems. When you are able to discover that space were your own piece should be fixed and fitted, to make the world a better place, then you will begin to be happy and the world would become happy too. It will now become the case of a round peg in a round hole, or else if you aren't able to discover yourself after exploring so much, you will be like a round peg in a square hole.

2. Career Research

As you've been able to explore yourself and you've seen the areas you may able to fit in best, you want to find out about careers. You have a list of careers, you ask questions, life is so easy now, you can go on to google and research for the careers that match what you've gotten from your self-exploration and self-discovery, when it comes to your strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats, your values and yearnings for satisfaction and remuneration. You search for the kind of career that exists in that domain that can fit into your passion and skills and all.

So, you look at the level you would need to enter, the qualifications you need. In some cases, you need professional qualifications, some cases you just need a degree, some cases you don't need any of the two if you have great skills. Nowadays, google, Facebook and the likes, are not so particular about college degrees, not because they are totally useless but because a lot of people have college degrees, but are not so useful to organizations. So, you need to find out what is required. Making your research may entail getting books to read up on them, looking for people you

were able to pen down in that field, ask them questions about how happy they are, how much they are earning, what it takes to get qualified, and so on; all what you need to know about the career. You also want to get online resources, you want to browse, need to fetch out knowledge as much as you need. About qualifications, in some cases, you may just need to do short courses to get yourself applied to that career.

3. Exploration and Experimentation

Here, you want to explore different careers, experiment and take chances and see how far you can go. It's very worthy to note that you must do goal setting, set your goals, very important. After setting your goals, it guides you as to what areas you should experiment with. In experimenting, you may need to forfeit reward, pay for experience as well as knowledge and discovery. Experimentation is more like adventure, you want to try hands on different careers, usually better to do it earlier in life, you do that through volunteering, so you go on a job and you do that free of charge and have a taste of how the job is like. It may be while you are working somewhere or while you are waiting to get a job. You may be lucky in some cases to get stipend while volunteering, the risk in this case is not on you but on the person who gave you the job to volunteer, as you probably don't have any experience in this area, learning on the job. Internship can be paid or unpaid, more like you are working under supervision, the internship position could be a volunteer position, it may be paid or unpaid. We can also say internship is a form of apprenticeship; you are being supervised by a person in higher position, most times put through by the person. You can also need to take trainings while either volunteering either within the organization or of the organization be it online training or you are going to a school in furthering your education so as to know more. You can also experiment by taking up a job, at least you are on a particular job. I know someone who was leaving on a particular job and was well paid but he left that job to a lesser-paying job. So that he could learn some particular skill he needed, and after that experience he had with the lesser-paying job, he leapt to a bigger job than the one he was doing even before that. Experimentation and exploration guides you to what you truly love.

4. Decision Making

Here, you should take an evaluation and make a list of all the pros and cons of your options. This pros and cons should include your experiences, challenges and even how your emotional wellbeing was affected while trying out these professions. After evaluating, you then make a decision also noting how much trouble you can endure doing this profession, how low you can accept as pay, and how much sacrifices you can make even without pay.

Those are basically what you need to do during decision making.

5. Final planning and action.

This involves making a list and searching for organizations that fit into your career goals. Searches could be done on the internet, magazines, newspapers, etc. It also involves preparing and updating your curriculum vitae and other credentials for employments.

6. Job search and acceptance.

This is the stage where you do the actual job search and take your CVs to organizations you'll like to work with even if there aren't vacancies at the moment. They just might need someone like you.

After that, you prepare for interviews. What you have to do at an interview is to prove to the organization that you can do the job you're being interviewed for and that you are the best person for the job. Organizations might want to know/hear what you can or are going to do but more importantly what you have done in the past. This is where volunteering and internships are really important and should have been taken seriously. You need to be confident and just see the interview just like another conversation.

Different Phases of Career

1. Exploration
2. Establishment
3. Mid-career
4. Late Career
5. Decline

1. Exploration Phase

This has been explained earlier. It is part of the planning process.

2. Establishment Phase

This is the early part of the career where one is just settling in and getting used to that particular career. It is usually between 25-44 though for some people, it is before this age range and even after for some. During this stage, an individual's performance increases and so do his skill and exposure.

3. Mid-Career Phase

During this stage, individual's career either continues to improve or just remains constant.

4. Late Career Phase

This is the phase where an individual tends to relax and play the role of an elder in the career as a result of the expertise and experience that one has gained.

5. Decline Phase

This is the last phase of an individual's career. It is the phase of retirement.

Benefits of Career Planning

1. Career planning ensures a constant supply of promotable employees.
2. It helps in improving the loyalty of employees.
3. Career planning encourages an employee's growth and development.
4. It discourages the negative attitude of superiors who are interested in suppressing the growth of the subordinates.

5. It ensures that senior management knows about the caliber and capacity of the employees who can move upwards.
6. It can always create a team of employees prepared enough to meet any contingency.
7. Career planning reduces labor turnover.
8. Every organization prepares succession planning towards which career planning is the first step.

RESILIENCE

What is Resilience?

Resilience is an individual's ability to withstand adversity or challenges and bounce back to initial status before difficult life events occurred. Being resilient does not mean that people don't experience stress, emotional upheaval or suffering.

Can you recall the last time you faced a challenge? A roadblock; a tremendous obstacle; an experience that hit you head-on and squeezed every joule of energy out of you. Was it a company project, a family crisis, a personal breaking point, or something else that shook you off your grounds and maybe even made you fall?

Challenges and adversities are common to everybody. What is not common to everyone, unfortunately, is the ability to, not only overcome challenges, but also flourish afterwards.

You may know some individuals who look strong and “okay”, until they get hit by a challenge (say a business failure) and they get shaken off their grounds. They get suicidal and lose all hopes that anything can ever work out. Instead of acknowledging that they failed, they acknowledge that they are failures. Some individuals, on the other hand, experience the same – or even worse – challenges and yet rise from it stronger and better as if nothing had happened.

For every individual that happens to fall under the second group, there is a common theme that makes them who they are—RESILIENCE.

Resilience is standing firm when, and after, everything around you has fallen. It is the ability to retain yourself as a strong and unbreakable force when a challenge or adversity hits. Resilience is having stamina – being able to stand firm and tall regardless of the situation. Resilience is the ability to engage in life with hope and humour, despite devastating losses that would have otherwise crippled you. Resilience is seeing life events and occurrences, no matter how devastating they are, as comprehensible, controllable, and meaningful.

Resilience is not only about overcoming hard situations; it is also overcoming them with “competent functioning” afterwards. Being resilient is analogous to being like a tree in a draught ravaged region – it may lose all its leaves during the adversity, but it will definitely grow back big when the rain arrives. It is the ability to keep doing what’s right and necessary, regardless of what speculations say.

Why Become Resilient?

How exactly does resilience affect a person’s progress? What effects does it have and how can it make you and I better? To find answers to these questions, let’s ask Emmy Werner – one of the earliest scientists to study resilience. She studied a cohort of children from Kauai, Hawaii. Kauai was quite poor and many of the participants of the study grew up with alcoholic and mentally ill parents, most of whom were out of work. Of the participants who grew up in this detrimental situations, two-thirds exhibited destructive behaviours (chronic unemployment, substance abuse, etc.) in their teens.

However, one-third of these youngsters did not exhibit these behaviours and were much more successful than their peers. The characteristic that made this possible was resilience. The smaller group were more resilient than their peers, and therefore, turned out to be more successful. They

could combat the challenges that were “handed over” to them by their parents and community and fight through it without quitting.

Resilience frees one from the shackles of past experiences, or social odds, and exposes one to new possibilities. A resilient individual does not accept the victim role or blame others when adverse situations arise, she responds by adapting herself, springing back, and halting the crisis.

Perhaps the most important aspect of resilience is that it can, like any other skill, be learned.

ADVANTAGES OF BEING RESILIENT

1. Increases job performance and work engagement.
2. Helps to sustain focus during distress.
3. Ability to cope everyday hassles and major stressors.
4. Protect against mental health problems - e.g, depression.
5. More emotionally stable.
6. Ability to cope with set backs.
7. Resilience helps to develop positive mood, which in turn improves emotional and physical health.

SOME CHALLENGES OF LOW RESILIENCE INCLUDE

1. Persistent illness.
2. Becoming isolated or clingy.
3. Being wordy.
4. Over reaction to normal stress.
5. Easily depressed or crying.
6. May have trouble sleeping.
7. Such a person with low resilience may engage in risky behaviours.

CAN I BECOME RESILIENT?

Resilience is not a trait that people either have or do not have. It involves behaviours, thoughts, and actions that can be learned by anyone.

Paradoxically, we were all born resilient, it is an obvious fact!

Have you ever seen a 1-year-old trying to walk? They try, and they fall and cry. They try again, and they fall again and cry. They try again, and in the process, they learn unique ways of keeping up. Yet, again, they fall and cry. This process goes on and on for weeks and even months. They try, fall, cry, and try again. This was the same process you and I took. And did we stop trying and give up? I guess

the answer is quite clear. That's resilience! If we had only tried once and stopped because we failed or just become depressed and tired, we might not be able to walk today.

As much as resilience was innately a part of us, there happened to be a disconnect between childhood and adulthood, where we lost that characteristic. This, psychologists say, is due primarily to the society. We get criticized after trying once and failing, and different options are immediately proffered. This had two effects on our mentality.

1. It reduced our resilience threshold. We were made to believe that after a few trial and no "go", you should just abandon the task. Hence, we only had to spend little time on things before discarding them and deem it impossible for to solve. Little challenges, therefore, have high chances of destabilizing the individual

2. It encouraged us to believe that challenges are insurmountable.

We are, however, not stuck with a low-resilient personality. Through deliberate and directed efforts, resilience can be built as a personal trait and as an organizational value.

HOW TO BECOME RESILIENT

1. **Transform your mindset:** The way you think about the problem, oftentimes, is the problem. We often see challenges as agents that are there to bring us down, when in fact, challenges come to make us stronger and better. You should never see a problem as insurmountable or insoluble. Every successful person has the mindset that setbacks will come, but I'll always rise from it stronger. Unsuccessful people have the mindset that when I have setbacks, I have failed.

2. **Ensure you have Positive Emotions:** One of the most helpful things to do is to ensure that one does not lose positivity. Negative self-talks, a lot of times, act as a catalyst that makes the challenge seem insurmountable. Avoid saying things like "I know I'm going to fail, after all" or "I can never overcome this challenge." Instead, say things like "I will not quit until I solve this challenge" or "I can do this, I must do this, I will do this."

3. **Be proactive:** Do not let things happen to you unexpectedly. Always try to anticipate future occurrences that have the potentials of destabilizing your plans. Being proactive will equip you to be aware of sudden events and thus, plan accordingly. With this, your resilience will increase, and you can confidently push through whatever the challenge is easily.

4. **Learn new things:** Resilience is easier to practice when you know how to get yourself out of the mess. When challenges come, a lot of people get stuck and stop trying because they have no knowledge of how to solve the problem. Learning is a central part of self-development; it increases your circle of influence and exposes you to useful knowledge. Learning, unlearning, and relearning will help in building resilience, based on the ability to always navigate through challenges.

5. **Be patient:** Resilience is synonymous to patience. Your resilience threshold often is your patience threshold. Some challenges require very little actions but huge amount of patience. It is however worthy to note that patience isn't the act of waiting, but your feelings, attitude, and behaviour while waiting.

6. **Understand that challenges will always come:** Challenges, alongside change, are constant. We all will face challenges at one point in life or another. This may be self-created or created by others. Understanding that challenges are a part of life and our individual development process, will expose us to benefits that can be realized from them, and hence, make us more resilient.

OTHER STRATEGIES TO BUILDING RESILIENCE

1. Seeing any crisis as being surmountable.
2. Accept that change is part of life.
3. Keep working on things that keep you focused on your goals .
4. Keep hope alive!
5. Keep working on yourself for self discovery.
6. Act whenever necessary! Don't practice 'wishful thinking'.
7. Be patient in the face of difficulty, knowing that the time of difficulty will pass.
8. See yourself in positive light always.
9. Mingle with people that seem resilient.
10. Practice self affirmation in areas you've been resilient in the past.
11. Work in developing a growth mindset.
12. Live a purpose-driven life.
13. Celebrate effort and little wins.

ORGANIZATIONAL RESILIENCE

Business today, is filled with countless threats and adversities; sudden government policy change, terrorism, migration, ruthless competition, irrational clients or customers, and even natural disasters. Happenings and changes that have the potentials of putting organizations out of business are now more common than ever. Aside business, global warming is threatening to wipe us all out from the face of earth. The complexities and adversities are now regular.

Despite all these devastating odds, some businesses are thriving and flourishing while many more are failing and dying.

Why are some organizations more successful in coping with, and responding effectively to, the complexity, volatility, and uncertainty of the current business climate? Why do some organizations, facing adversity, get engrossed in the negative, while others successfully seize the opportunity to adapt and progress? The reason for this is **ORGANISATIONAL RESILIENCE**.

What is Organizational Resilience?

Organizational resilience refers to the ability of organizations and companies to foresee, prepare for, successfully combat, and then emerge stronger from adversity. It is the characteristics possessed by organizations that enable them to, not only pass the test of time, but also remain relevant in their industry.

The threats and adversities in the business world today are huge and often hard to tackle. Many organizations are thrown off balance once they are hit with these adversities, some organizations manage to survive, but only few organizations flourish after a major setback or adversity. Organizational resilience is not only about bouncing back from a setback, it is about bouncing forward.

In the face of adversity, say a major economic crisis, organizations are tested strongly as to their ability to keep going after the challenge. The internet bubble saw to the creation of hundreds of tech startups in Silicon Valley. Every entrepreneur wanted to start an Internet company; every investor wanted to invest in the tech companies because of the perceived high income. However, when the bubble burst, hundreds of companies closed doors and investors lost big time. Only a few companies managed to scale through the crisis. One of these companies is PayPal. PayPal survived the dot com boom and even flourished afterwards, despite being a company that had had a lot of failures in its early years. This post-crisis success is due to the resilience instilled into the organizations by the founders and leaders. They could understand that despite the unfriendly nature of things, there were chances for them to succeed. With this mindset, they pushed through the crisis and emerged extremely successful. In just four months, PayPal's subscribers shot up from 10000 to a million.

BUILDING A RESILIENT ORGANISATION

Resilience in organizations is demonstrated most when challenges arise. It is the organizations approach to these challenges that determines their level of resilience. Business leaders are increasingly aware that organizational resilience will help them build their businesses and protect their continuing performance. Companies recognize the need to be resilient but only few have a clearly defined strategy that is utilized whenever their resilience is tested. Resilience can be built in organizations in the following ways:

1. Change how you approach adversities. When setbacks come, organizations can react in two ways.
 - a) Defensive reaction
 - b) Progressive reaction.

In most cases of adversity, organizations react defensively, by trying to stop bad things from happening. Organizations that make use of defensive reactions in responding to adversity take mindful on-the-spot actions by trying everything possible to solve the crisis from having devastating effects on the organization or take preventative control by taking actions to prevent the occurrences of adversity.

Progressive reaction, on the other hand, seeks, not only to stop bad things from happening, but to also make good things happen. Organizations react progressively by optimizing their current performance – by improving their products, enhancing their services, etc. – or taking adaptive

innovation – by investing in new market, pioneering new fields and way of doing things. Progressive reaction to adversity will improve the resilience of your organization.

2. Play the infinite game. Simon Sinek, in his book 'The Infinite Game', emphasizes the need for organizations to play with an infinite mindset. For organizations to be resilient, they must have goals that are beyond just hitting a financial target, or increasing client base, or being the number 1 in the industry. Every organization that will thrive in the face of setbacks and remain resilient should have a 'just cause' that they are pursuing. Something that is beyond the numbers and can serve as a catalyst to propel action, even when the odds are against success.

3. Value your employees. The way you treat your employees is the way they treat your clients. When your employees have the feeling that they are valued and safe in the organization, they will be willing to put in their sweat, blood, and tears to keep pushing through the adversity. Every great company that survived a major adversity did so by the power of their employees, combined with other factors. You should value your employees if you want to build an organization that will thrive during and after adversities.

4. Define winning to include making progress and not only when the job gets finally done.

5. Keep working on developing very resilient workers that will make up a resilient workforce!

The way to achieve this is to keep developing your workers emotional intelligence. Trainings, coaching, activities and engagements that will challenge their emotional intelligence will help grow their resilience.